

Beyond the Beach:
A Secondary Data Analysis of Micro-Entrepreneurship Survival Strategies
in Philippine Tourism Enclaves During Economic Disruption

A Qualitative Research Study



Prof. Alfred Lopez, MBA, EdD

Email: newhorizonextension@gmail.com

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ABSTRACT

This study examines the economic survival strategies employed by micro-entrepreneurs operating within Philippine tourism enclaves during periods of economic disruption. Using a qualitative secondary data analysis (QSDA) design situated within an interpretivist paradigm, the research synthesizes evidence from peer-reviewed academic literature, government reports, and institutional studies covering the period 2013 to 2024. The analysis is organized around four research questions addressing the nature of economic disruptions, the survival strategies deployed by micro-entrepreneurs, a typology of those strategies, and the policy and institutional conditions that enable or constrain micro-enterprise survival. Findings reveal that Philippine tourism micro-entrepreneurs face a structurally recurring and compounding pattern of disruptions — spanning pandemic events, natural disasters, policy interventions, and security crises — that progressively depletes their adaptive capacity across successive shocks. Despite severe structural constraints, micro-entrepreneurs deploy rich survival strategy portfolios combining operational contraction, livelihood diversification, social capital activation through culturally embedded mechanisms such as *utang na loob*, *bayanihan*, and *paluwagan*, and selective institutional engagement. A four-quadrant typology organized along temporal and resource-orientation axes reveals a resilience trap in which the most vulnerable operators — informally registered, island-based, women-operated, and low-capitalized — are structurally confined to short-term strategies and excluded from transformative adaptation. The study further documents a policy landscape characterized by formalization bias, inter-agency fragmentation, and disbursement delays that systematically exclude the most vulnerable micro-entrepreneurs from institutional support. Recommendations are addressed to the Department of Tourism, Department of Trade and Industry, DOLE, Local

Government Units, and academic researchers, with priority given to the elimination of formalization requirements as preconditions for crisis relief eligibility.

Keywords: *tourism micro-entrepreneurship; economic disruption; survival strategies; resilience trap; informal economy; sustainable livelihoods; Philippines; tourism enclaves; qualitative secondary data analysis; social capital; bayanihan; paluwagan; MSME policy; post-pandemic recovery; livelihood diversification*

CHAPTER I: INTRODUCTION

Background of the Study

Tourism has long been recognized as a significant driver of economic growth and poverty alleviation in developing nations, particularly in Southeast Asia. In the Philippines, the sector contributes substantially to gross domestic product (GDP), employment generation, and foreign exchange earnings. Yet beneath the macro-level statistics lies a more nuanced economic ecosystem — one populated primarily by micro-entrepreneurs whose livelihoods are inextricably tied to the ebb and flow of tourist arrivals. These actors — the sari-sari store operators, tricycle drivers, food stall owners, souvenir vendors, and informal tour guides operating within tourism enclaves — constitute the bedrock of community-level economic participation in destinations such as Boracay, Palawan, Siargao, Bohol, and Batangas.

The Philippine tourism industry demonstrated robust performance in the years preceding 2020, with the Department of Tourism (DOT) recording over 8.2 million international visitor arrivals in 2019, generating approximately PHP 482.15 billion in receipts (Department of Tourism [DOT], 2020). However, the onset of the COVID-19 pandemic in early 2020 precipitated an unprecedented collapse of global tourism demand. International arrivals in the Philippines fell by 82% in 2020, devastating tourism-dependent communities and exposing the extreme vulnerability of micro-entrepreneurs who lacked the financial buffers, institutional support, and adaptive capacity available to larger firms (United Nations World Tourism Organization [UNWTO], 2021).

Economic disruptions in tourism-dependent economies are not unprecedented. Prior to COVID-19, Philippine tourism enclaves experienced disruptions from natural disasters including Typhoon Haiyan (Yolanda) in 2013, the Zamboanga City conflict in the same year, and the Boracay closure ordered by President Rodrigo Duterte in 2018 for environmental rehabilitation.

Each event produced cascading effects on micro-entrepreneurial activity, yet systematic documentation of survival strategies employed by these actors remains sparse in Philippine academic literature (Alampay & Umezaki, 2019).

Internationally, the literature on small and micro-enterprise resilience during economic shocks has grown considerably. Scholars such as Wasilczuk (2000) and Doern et al. (2019) have documented the adaptive strategies of small firms during crises, including cost reduction, product diversification, informal credit mobilization, and community-based resource pooling. In the tourism sector specifically, Dahles and Bras (1999) pioneered scholarship on informal tourism entrepreneurship in developing Asia, arguing that micro-entrepreneurs in tourist destinations develop context-specific survival repertoires shaped by social networks, geographic position, and institutional environments. More recent contributions by Novelli et al. (2018) and Farmaki et al. (2020) have extended this analysis to crisis contexts, demonstrating that micro-enterprise survival is mediated by access to social capital, government support mechanisms, and the structural characteristics of destination economies.

In the Philippine context, research on tourism entrepreneurship has predominantly focused on policy frameworks, destination competitiveness, and macro-economic impacts (Paguia, 2018; Sabanal & Bautista, 2021). Studies specifically examining the survival strategies of micro-entrepreneurs in tourism enclaves during periods of economic disruption remain limited, and those that do exist tend to rely on cross-sectional survey data that capture snapshots rather than processes. This gap is particularly consequential given the structural characteristics of Philippine tourism, where informal and micro-scale economic actors constitute the majority of tourism-related businesses in coastal and island destinations (Asian Development Bank [ADB], 2021).

This study addresses that gap by conducting a qualitative secondary data analysis — drawing on peer-reviewed literature, government reports, institutional studies, and policy documents — to examine the documented survival strategies of micro-entrepreneurs in Philippine tourism enclaves during economic disruptions. By synthesizing existing knowledge and identifying patterns across disruption contexts, this research aims to contribute both to academic understanding and to evidence-based policy formulation for micro-enterprise support in the Philippine tourism sector.

Statement of the Problem

Despite the critical role of micro-entrepreneurs in sustaining local tourism economies, their survival dynamics during economic disruptions remain underexplored in Philippine scholarship. This study examines the economic survival strategies employed by micro-entrepreneurs operating within Philippine tourism enclaves during periods of economic disruption through a qualitative analysis of secondary data sources including published research, government documents, and institutional reports. Specifically, it seeks to answer the following questions:

1. What economic disruptions have most significantly impacted micro-entrepreneurs in Philippine tourism enclaves, as documented in existing literature, government records, and institutional reports?
2. What economic survival strategies are most frequently documented among micro-entrepreneurs in Philippine tourism enclaves, and under what structural conditions — such as access to capital, market dependency, and supply chain vulnerability — do they emerge?

3. What typology of survival strategies can be constructed from existing secondary data on tourism micro-entrepreneurship in the Philippines, and how do geographic, sectoral, and socioeconomic variables mediate survival outcomes?
4. What policy and institutional factors are identified in the literature as either enabling or constraining micro-entrepreneurial survival, and what gaps remain in current scholarship and governance frameworks addressing Philippine tourism micro-enterprises?

Theoretical Framework

This study is anchored on three complementary theoretical lenses that together provide a robust explanatory architecture for understanding micro-entrepreneurial survival in tourism enclaves during economic disruption.

The first is the Resilience Theory as articulated in entrepreneurship scholarship by Doern et al. (2019) and further developed in the context of small tourism businesses by Dahles and Susilowati (2015). Resilience theory posits that firms facing adversarial conditions develop adaptive capacities — the ability to absorb shocks, reorganize, and maintain functionality — through the mobilization of internal resources (financial reserves, skills, networks) and external supports (community solidarity, institutional assistance). In the tourism micro-enterprise context, resilience is not merely an individual firm attribute but an emergent property of the broader socio-economic ecosystem within which entrepreneurs operate.

The second theoretical anchor is the Sustainable Livelihoods Framework (SLF), originally developed by Chambers and Conway (1992) and later institutionalized by the UK Department for International Development (DFID, 1999). The SLF conceptualizes livelihood strategies — including entrepreneurial activities — as shaped by five capital assets: human capital (skills,

education, health), social capital (networks, trust, reciprocity), physical capital (tools, infrastructure), financial capital (savings, credit, remittances), and natural capital (environmental resources). For micro-entrepreneurs in Philippine tourism enclaves, natural capital — coastal environments, marine resources, scenic landscapes — is particularly salient both as an asset and as a vulnerability, since tourism demand is fundamentally conditioned by environmental quality and destination image.

The third theoretical lens is Informal Economy Theory, drawing on the foundational work of Hart (1973) and its subsequent elaboration by De Soto (1989) and Portes et al. (1989). Informal economy theory is essential for contextualizing the majority of Philippine tourism micro-entrepreneurs, who operate outside formal regulatory frameworks, lack access to institutional credit, and depend on social and kinship networks for economic survival. The theory illuminates how informality simultaneously limits the adaptive resources available to micro-entrepreneurs (exclusion from government relief programs, inability to access formal credit) and enables flexible, low-cost survival strategies (unregulated operating hours, cost-sharing arrangements, barter economies) unavailable to formal sector firms.

Together, these three frameworks generate a multi-level analytical architecture: Resilience Theory focuses attention on adaptive processes at the firm level; the Sustainable Livelihoods Framework situates firm-level adaptation within a broader asset-vulnerability context; and Informal Economy Theory illuminates the institutional and structural conditions that shape what survival strategies are available to, and deployed by, tourism micro-entrepreneurs in the Philippine context.

Conceptual Framework

The conceptual framework of this study operationalizes the three theoretical lenses into an analytical model specifically designed for the Philippine tourism micro-enterprise context. The framework is organized around four interrelated constructs.

The first construct is Economic Disruption Context, which encompasses the nature, severity, duration, and geographic scope of disruptions affecting Philippine tourism enclaves. This includes pandemic events (COVID-19, SARS), natural disasters (typhoons, earthquakes), environmental policy interventions (Boracay closure), and global economic shocks. The disruption context shapes the magnitude of economic stress experienced by micro-entrepreneurs and activates survival responses.

The second construct is the Capital Asset Profile of micro-entrepreneurs, drawn from the Sustainable Livelihoods Framework. This encompasses the five capital assets — human, social, physical, financial, and natural — as they are configured for tourism micro-entrepreneurs in specific enclave contexts. Capital asset profiles vary significantly across geographic locations (island vs. coastal vs. urban tourism zones), sectors (food, transport, accommodation, retail), and individual characteristics (gender, age, education, years in business), producing heterogeneous adaptive capacities.

The third construct is Survival Strategy Typology, representing the central analytical output of this study. Building on Dahles and Bras (1999) and Novelli et al. (2018), this study posits that survival strategies can be organized along two axes: temporal orientation (short-term crisis response vs. long-term adaptive transformation) and resource orientation (internal resource mobilization vs. external resource acquisition). This produces a four-quadrant typology: (1) internal-short-term strategies (cost cutting, asset liquidation, labor reduction); (2) internal-long-

term strategies (product diversification, skills upgrading, business model transformation); (3) external-short-term strategies (social network activation, informal credit, community solidarity); and (4) external-long-term strategies (institutional support access, policy engagement, market repositioning).

The fourth construct is Institutional and Policy Environment, which mediates the relationship between capital asset profiles and survival strategy adoption. Government programs (MSME support, tourism relief funds), LGU policies, access to microfinance, and industry association membership all shape which survival strategies are feasible for micro-entrepreneurs in specific enclave contexts.

The analytical flow of the framework proceeds from disruption context through capital asset profile and institutional environment to survival strategy adoption, with outcomes assessed in terms of business continuity, employment retention, and livelihood sustainability. Feedback loops between outcomes and capital asset profiles capture the dynamic, iterative nature of micro-entrepreneurial adaptation over the course of economic disruptions.

Significance of the Study

This study makes contributions at multiple levels — academic, policy, and practical — that justify its undertaking and speak to the urgency of the research questions addressed.

Academically, this study contributes to the nascent but growing literature on tourism micro-entrepreneurship in developing Asia by synthesizing dispersed empirical evidence into a coherent analytical framework. By developing an empirically grounded typology of survival strategies specifically calibrated to the Philippine context, the study advances theoretical integration between resilience theory, sustainable livelihoods frameworks, and informal economy

scholarship. It also demonstrates the methodological value of qualitative secondary data analysis for generating substantive insights in contexts where primary data collection is constrained — a contribution of particular relevance to researchers working in resource-limited academic environments.

For policy makers, this study provides an evidence base for the design and targeting of government support programs for tourism micro-enterprises during economic disruptions. By identifying the structural conditions that enable or constrain survival strategy adoption, the study offers actionable guidance for the Department of Tourism, the Department of Trade and Industry, and Local Government Units seeking to strengthen the resilience of tourism-dependent communities. The identification of policy gaps in existing governance frameworks for Philippine tourism micro-enterprises provides a roadmap for legislative and programmatic reform.

For tourism industry practitioners and development organizations, the survival strategy typology developed in this study provides a practical diagnostic tool for assessing micro-enterprise vulnerability and designing targeted capacity-building interventions. Non-governmental organizations, microfinance institutions, and tourism industry associations operating in Philippine tourism enclaves can use the framework to identify the specific capital asset deficits and institutional barriers that most severely constrain micro-entrepreneurial survival in their areas of engagement.

Finally, for Filipino micro-entrepreneurs themselves and their communities, this study contributes to the documentation and validation of the survival knowledge that communities have generated through their lived experience of economic disruptions. By making this knowledge

visible in academic and policy discourse, the study affirms the agency and resourcefulness of micro-entrepreneurs who constitute the human foundation of Philippine tourism.

Scope and Limitations

This study is delimited to the analysis of secondary data sources — including peer-reviewed academic publications, government reports, institutional studies, and policy documents — pertaining to micro-entrepreneurship in Philippine tourism enclaves. The study does not involve the collection of primary data through interviews, surveys, focus groups, or ethnographic observation. As such, the findings are bounded by the scope, quality, and representativeness of the secondary data sources available and accessed.

Geographically, the study focuses on Philippine tourism enclaves, understood as geographic concentrations of tourism activity in coastal, island, and nature-based destinations. Urban tourism contexts (Metro Manila, Cebu City) are considered only where secondary sources explicitly address micro-entrepreneurship dynamics comparable to enclave settings. The study covers economic disruptions occurring from 2013 to 2024, with particular emphasis on the COVID-19 pandemic period (2020–2023), which represents the most extensively documented disruption event in the secondary literature.

Several limitations constrain the conclusions that can be drawn from this study. First, the secondary literature on Philippine tourism micro-entrepreneurship is uneven in geographic coverage, with certain destinations (Boracay, Palawan) better represented than others (Samar-Leyte, Camiguin, Batanes). This unevenness may introduce geographic bias into the survival strategy typology developed. Second, secondary data sources vary in methodological rigor, with some government reports and institutional studies employing limited sampling strategies or non-

transparent analytical procedures. The quality of conclusions drawn from these sources is necessarily constrained by their methodological limitations.

Third, as a qualitative secondary data analysis, this study cannot establish causal relationships between structural conditions and survival outcomes; it can identify associations and patterns but not determine directionality or magnitude of effects. Fourth, rapidly evolving policy environments — particularly in the post-pandemic recovery period — mean that some institutional and policy findings may be superseded by developments occurring after the study's data coverage period.

These limitations are acknowledged not to diminish the study's contribution but to situate its findings appropriately and to identify directions for future primary research that can build on the analytical framework developed here.

CHAPTER II: REVIEW OF RELATED LITERATURE

Introduction to the Review

This chapter synthesizes existing scholarship on four thematic areas directly relevant to the research questions: (1) tourism micro-entrepreneurship in developing economies; (2) economic disruptions and small enterprise survival; (3) the Philippine tourism economy and micro-enterprise landscape; and (4) policy and institutional frameworks for micro-enterprise support in tourism contexts. The review draws on peer-reviewed journals, book chapters, government reports, and institutional studies, and concludes with an identification of research gaps that this study addresses.

Tourism Micro-Entrepreneurship in Developing Economies

The study of micro-entrepreneurship in tourism contexts has developed as a distinct subfield within tourism studies over the past three decades. Dahles and Bras (1999) produced a foundational analysis of small-scale tourism entrepreneurs in Indonesia, demonstrating that these actors develop highly context-specific survival strategies shaped by their position within destination power structures, their access to tourist flows, and their embeddedness in local social networks. Their work established that tourism micro-entrepreneurs are not simply passive participants in tourism economies but active agents who deploy creativity and social intelligence to carve out economic niches within larger destination systems.

Ateljevic and Doorne (2000) extended this analysis to lifestyle entrepreneurship, arguing that many small tourism business operators in developing economies are motivated not primarily by profit maximization but by non-economic goals including cultural preservation, community belonging, and quality of life maintenance. This insight is significant for understanding survival strategy choices: micro-entrepreneurs who are deeply embedded in community and place are more likely to deploy community solidarity-based survival strategies and less likely to exit the market during disruptions, even when continued operation is economically irrational in the short term.

Scheyvens (2007) and Bolwell and Weinz (2008) examined the relationship between tourism micro-entrepreneurship and poverty alleviation in developing economies, finding that the linkages between tourism growth and micro-enterprise income are highly mediated by structural factors including market access, infrastructure quality, and the distribution of power within destination supply chains. Their work highlights that micro-entrepreneurs in tourism enclaves frequently occupy the lowest-margin segments of tourism value chains, making them highly vulnerable to demand shocks and limiting their capacity to accumulate the financial reserves needed to weather economic disruptions.

More recent contributions by Farmaki et al. (2020) and Alonso et al. (2021) have examined micro-enterprise responses to crises including the 2008 global financial crisis and the COVID-19 pandemic, identifying digitalization, product diversification, and community cooperative formation as emerging survival strategies among small tourism operators. However, these studies are predominantly situated in European and Latin American contexts, and their findings cannot be directly transposed to the institutional and cultural environments of Southeast Asian developing economies.

Economic Disruptions and Small Enterprise Survival

The literature on small enterprise survival during economic disruptions has identified several consistent patterns across diverse crisis contexts. Doern et al. (2019), in a systematic review of entrepreneurship and crisis literature, identified four primary categories of firm-level response to economic shocks: reactive responses (immediate cost reduction, operational contraction); adaptive responses (product and market modifications); proactive responses (opportunity recognition and exploitation within the crisis context); and exit responses (temporary suspension or permanent closure). The distribution of responses across these categories is shaped by firm characteristics (size, age, sector, formalization status) and environmental factors (crisis severity, institutional support availability, market structure).

Wasilczuk (2000) found that social capital — particularly strong ties to family, community, and business networks — is among the most powerful predictors of small enterprise survival during economic disruptions. This finding has been consistently replicated in subsequent studies across diverse geographic and sectoral contexts (Frankenberger et al., 2013; Herbane, 2019), and is particularly relevant to the Philippine context where kinship networks (*utang na loob*, *bayanihan*) constitute a fundamental organizing principle of economic life.

Williams and Vorley (2015) examined the survival strategies of small enterprises following economic crises in transition economies, finding that institutional voids — gaps in government support systems, credit markets, and regulatory frameworks — both constrain formal adaptive strategies and create space for informal survival mechanisms. This dialectical relationship between formal institutional absence and informal adaptive capacity is a recurring theme in developing economy entrepreneurship literature and is directly applicable to the Philippine tourism micro-enterprise context.

In the specific context of tourism, Hall et al. (2017) developed a comprehensive framework for understanding tourism enterprise responses to crises, distinguishing between first-order responses (immediate operational adjustments), second-order responses (strategic repositioning), and third-order responses (systemic transformation). Their framework suggests that the majority of micro-enterprises in developing economy tourism contexts are constrained to first-order responses by their limited resource bases, and that access to institutional support is the primary determinant of whether firms can achieve second- or third-order adaptive responses.

The Philippine Tourism Economy and Micro-Enterprise Landscape

The Philippine tourism sector is characterized by significant structural dualism: a formal sector dominated by large hotel chains, airlines, and tour operators, and an informal sector comprising millions of micro and small enterprises that provide the majority of ground-level tourism services (ADB, 2021). The DOT (2020) estimated that approximately 92% of tourism-related businesses in the Philippines qualify as micro-enterprises under the MSMED Council definition (capitalization of less than PHP 3 million), with the majority concentrated in food and beverage services, transportation, and souvenir retail.

Paguia (2018) conducted a detailed analysis of tourism micro-enterprise dynamics in Palawan, finding that the majority of micro-operators in the destination had capitalization of less than PHP 500,000, operated without formal business registration, lacked access to institutional credit, and depended on tourist season income to cover annual household expenses. Her findings highlight the extreme financial fragility of tourism micro-entrepreneurs in enclave destinations and their limited capacity to maintain operations through extended demand disruptions.

The Boracay closure of 2018 provided a rare natural experiment for studying micro-enterprise responses to sudden, government-imposed tourism disruptions. Sabanal and Bautista (2021) analyzed the impacts of the six-month closure on micro-entrepreneurs in the destination, documenting significant livelihood displacement, forced migration, and enterprise exit among the most vulnerable operators. However, they also documented remarkable resilience and adaptation among better-networked and more financially resourced operators, including pivot to domestic supply chains, participation in government livelihood programs, and development of new product offerings targeting the post-closure rehabilitated destination.

The COVID-19 pandemic represented a shock of unprecedented severity for Philippine tourism. The DOT (2021) estimated that over 5.7 million jobs in tourism-related sectors were affected, with micro-enterprises bearing a disproportionate share of employment losses. Government responses including the TUPAD (Tulong Panghanapbuhay sa Ating Disadvantaged/Displaced Workers) program and DOLE financial assistance reached some tourism micro-entrepreneurs but were widely criticized for inadequate coverage and disbursement delays (Philippine Institute for Development Studies [PIDS], 2021).

Policy and Institutional Frameworks for Micro-Enterprise Support

The policy landscape for tourism micro-enterprise support in the Philippines is fragmented across multiple agencies including the DOT, DTI, DOLE, and LGUs, with coordination challenges limiting the effectiveness of support programs during disruptions (PIDS, 2021). The Magna Carta for Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises (Republic Act 9501, as amended by RA 10644) provides the primary legislative framework for MSME support, but its provisions are predominantly oriented toward formal sector firms and do not adequately address the specific vulnerabilities of informally operating tourism micro-entrepreneurs.

Microfinance institutions, including the People's Credit and Finance Corporation (PCFC) and a network of rural banks and cooperatives, provide some financial access for micro-entrepreneurs, but tourism-specific microfinance products remain limited (Bangko Sentral ng Pilipinas [BSP], 2022). The collapse of tourism income during disruptions simultaneously increases the credit needs of micro-entrepreneurs and reduces their creditworthiness under standard microfinance assessment criteria, creating a financing gap precisely when it is most needed.

At the local government level, LGU responses to tourism disruptions have varied considerably across destinations, with some (notably Siargao and Bohol) demonstrating more proactive and community-centered support approaches than others (Alampay & Umezaki, 2019). LGU capacity for effective micro-enterprise support during disruptions is constrained by fiscal resources, administrative capacity, and the quality of local governance, producing significant geographic variation in survival outcomes across Philippine tourism enclaves.

Research Gaps

The review of related literature reveals several significant gaps that this study is designed to address. First, while international literature on tourism micro-enterprise resilience is growing, the Philippines remains comparatively understudied relative to its significance as a developing economy tourism destination. The existing Philippine-focused literature is geographically concentrated in a small number of destinations (Boracay, Palawan), leaving the dynamics of micro-entrepreneurship in less prominent tourism enclaves largely undocumented.

Second, existing studies predominantly employ quantitative methods (surveys, econometric analysis) that capture the scope and magnitude of disruption impacts but are less effective at illuminating the processes by which micro-entrepreneurs construct and deploy survival strategies. Qualitative analysis of these processes — drawing on the rich documentary evidence available in government reports, institutional studies, and academic case studies — can generate the process-level insights necessary for effective policy design.

Third, while survival strategies during individual disruption events (particularly COVID-19) have been studied, cross-disruption comparative analysis — examining how survival strategy patterns differ across disruption types (pandemic, natural disaster, policy intervention) — is virtually absent from the Philippine literature. Such comparative analysis is essential for developing generalizable frameworks applicable to future disruption events.

Fourth, the role of gender in mediating survival strategy access and effectiveness among Philippine tourism micro-entrepreneurs has received very limited scholarly attention, despite evidence from other developing economy contexts that women-owned micro-enterprises face systematically different vulnerability profiles and adaptive constraints (ILO, 2020). This gap represents both an analytical lacuna and a policy blind spot.

Research Synthesis

The synthesis of literature reviewed in this chapter supports several overarching conclusions that ground the analytical framework of this study and guide its empirical analysis.

The survival of tourism micro-enterprises during economic disruptions is neither random nor purely a function of individual entrepreneurial talent; it is systematically shaped by the interplay of capital asset configurations, social network embeddedness, institutional environment quality, and the nature of the disruption itself. Micro-entrepreneurs with more diverse capital asset portfolios — particularly those with stronger social capital and some degree of financial reserve — consistently demonstrate greater adaptive capacity across disruption contexts.

The informal status of the majority of Philippine tourism micro-entrepreneurs is a double-edged sword: it enables the deployment of flexible, low-cost survival strategies unavailable to formal sector firms, while simultaneously excluding entrepreneurs from the formal institutional support systems most likely to enable substantive adaptive transformation. Policy interventions that fail to engage the informal character of tourism micro-enterprise ecosystems will systematically miss their most vulnerable target population.

Survival strategies are not uniformly distributed across tourism enclave micro-entrepreneurs; they are differentiated by sector, geography, gender, and social network position in ways that generate significant heterogeneity in outcomes even within the same disruption event and the same destination. A typological approach — organizing observed strategies into analytically coherent categories — is therefore essential for generating policy-relevant insights that can be targeted to the specific circumstances of different micro-entrepreneur populations.

Finally, the literature consistently reveals that the post-disruption recovery period — not the crisis peak itself — is the critical window during which micro-entrepreneur survival or exit is determined. Survival strategies that maintain minimum operational viability through the crisis period create the platform for recovery-stage adaptation; strategies that sacrifice operational continuity for short-term resource conservation risk permanent enterprise exit even after the disruption resolves. This temporal dynamic is a central analytical theme that guides the interpretation of secondary data evidence throughout this study.

CHAPTER III: RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

Introduction

This chapter presents the methodological design of the study, detailing the philosophical assumptions, research design, data sources, data collection procedures, analytical framework, trustworthiness measures, and ethical considerations that govern the conduct of the research. The methodology is deliberately constructed to align with the qualitative nature of the inquiry, the secondary data character of the evidence base, and the interpretive goals of the research — specifically, the construction of an empirically grounded typology of micro-entrepreneurial survival strategies in Philippine tourism enclaves during economic disruption.

Methodological transparency is a foundational commitment of this study. Because qualitative secondary data analysis occupies a distinct position within the research methods landscape — neither a traditional literature review nor a primary qualitative study — it is essential

to articulate clearly the procedures and criteria that govern data selection, interpretation, and synthesis. This chapter provides that articulation in sufficient detail to enable readers to assess the credibility, transferability, and confirmability of the study's findings.

Research Design

Qualitative Research Paradigm

This study is situated within the interpretivist research paradigm, which holds that social reality is not a fixed, objective phenomenon awaiting discovery but is constructed through the meanings that social actors — in this case, micro-entrepreneurs, policy makers, and researchers — assign to their experiences and circumstances (Creswell & Poth, 2018). The interpretivist paradigm is appropriate for this study because the central research questions are fundamentally concerned with meaning-making: how micro-entrepreneurs understand and respond to economic disruption, how researchers and policy analysts have characterized their strategies, and what patterns of meaning can be discerned across diverse documentary sources.

The ontological position of the study is constructivist: it holds that the survival strategies documented in secondary sources are not simply neutral descriptions of objective behaviors but are shaped by the theoretical frameworks, conceptual categories, and methodological choices of the researchers and document authors who produced them. The analytical task of this study is therefore not simply to aggregate findings but to interpret them — to engage critically with the frameworks through which they were generated and to construct a more integrated understanding than any individual source provides.

The epistemological position is that knowledge about micro-entrepreneurial survival emerges from the systematic, reflexive engagement with the documentary record produced by

scholars, government agencies, and institutions who have studied these phenomena directly. As Bowen (2009) argues, documentary analysis conducted within an interpretivist framework is not a second-best substitute for primary research but a methodologically legitimate approach that can generate insights unavailable through primary data collection — particularly in contexts where the phenomena of interest are distributed across time, geography, and organizational settings that no single primary study can encompass.

Qualitative Secondary Data Analysis

The specific research design employed in this study is Qualitative Secondary Data Analysis (QSDA), a methodology that involves the systematic collection, critical appraisal, and interpretive analysis of qualitative data generated by prior researchers or documentary sources (Heaton, 2004; Smith, 2008). QSDA is distinguished from quantitative meta-analysis by its commitment to preserving the contextual richness and interpretive complexity of source materials, rather than reducing them to numerical effect sizes or aggregated statistics.

Within the QSDA tradition, this study employs what Heaton (2004) terms an amplified analysis approach: rather than reanalyzing raw primary data from previous studies (which is unavailable), the study analyzes the published findings, interpretations, and conclusions of prior research alongside the documentary evidence contained in government reports, institutional studies, and policy documents. This approach is appropriate when the research question requires synthesis across a broader evidence base than any single primary study addresses, and when the goal is theoretical integration and typology construction rather than the generation of new empirical data.

The QSDA design aligns with the study's research questions in three specific ways. First, the focus on documenting patterns across disruption events (RQ1) requires a cross-study synthesis that primary data collection from a single disruption context cannot provide. Second, the construction of a survival strategy typology (RQ3) requires sufficient breadth of evidence to identify variations as well as patterns — breadth achievable only through systematic analysis of multiple secondary sources. Third, the identification of policy gaps (RQ4) is inherently a secondary data task, requiring engagement with the documentary record of government programs, institutional assessments, and policy evaluations.

Data Sources

Source Categories

The data for this study are drawn from five categories of secondary sources, selected for their relevance to the research questions and their capacity to provide complementary perspectives on the phenomenon of micro-entrepreneurial survival in Philippine tourism enclaves. Table 1 presents the source categories, specific sources within each category, and the rationale for their inclusion.

Table 1
Source Categories and Rationale for Inclusion

Source Category	Specific Sources	Rationale
Peer-reviewed journals	Annals of Tourism Research, Tourism Management, Journal of Small Business Management, Asian Journal of Tourism Research, Philippine Journal of Development	Provides empirically validated, theoretically grounded findings on micro-enterprise dynamics
Government reports	DOT annual reports, DTI MSME statistics, DOLE labor impact assessments, NEDA socioeconomic reports	Provides official data on policy landscape, enterprise demographics, and disruption impacts

Institutional studies	PIDS discussion papers, ADB assessments, ILO reports, UNWTO publications, BSP financial inclusion reports	Provides regional and international comparative context and policy evaluation data
Academic books and book chapters	Monographs on tourism entrepreneurship, informal economy, and livelihood frameworks	Provides theoretical depth and historical context unavailable in journal articles
Theses and dissertations	Philippine-based graduate theses on tourism MSMEs from CHED-recognized institutions	Provides locally grounded primary research not published in international journals

The diversity of source categories is intentional. Peer-reviewed academic sources provide theoretical grounding and methodological rigor; government and institutional reports provide empirical data on the scope and nature of disruption impacts; academic books provide historical depth; and Philippine graduate theses provide locally grounded perspectives that may not yet have reached international publication channels. Together, these source categories constitute a multi-perspectival evidence base capable of supporting the interpretive synthesis goals of the study.

Inclusion and Exclusion Criteria

To ensure the relevance, quality, and manageability of the secondary data corpus, systematic inclusion and exclusion criteria were applied during the source identification and selection process. These criteria are presented in Table 2.

Table 2
Inclusion and Exclusion Criteria for Secondary Data Sources

Criterion	Inclusion	Exclusion
Geographic focus	Philippine tourism destinations	Non-Philippine contexts (unless comparative)
Enterprise scale	Micro and small enterprises (MSMEs)	Large corporations, hotel chains
Time period	2013–2024	Publications before 2013

Language	English and Filipino	Other languages without translation
Source type	Peer-reviewed journals, government reports, institutional studies, policy documents	Opinion blogs, unverified online sources, undated grey literature
Subject matter	Tourism entrepreneurship, micro-enterprise survival, disruption response	Macro tourism demand studies with no enterprise-level analysis

International sources from non-Philippine contexts are included selectively where they provide theoretical frameworks, comparative benchmarks, or conceptual tools directly applicable to the Philippine case. This is particularly relevant for foundational works on tourism micro-entrepreneurship, resilience theory, and the sustainable livelihoods framework, which originate primarily from non-Philippine scholarship but have direct theoretical applicability to the study's subject matter.

Data Collection Procedure

Database and Repository Search

Peer-reviewed sources were identified through systematic searches of the following academic databases and repositories: Scopus, Web of Science, Google Scholar, EBSCO Host, the Philippine E-Journals (PEJ) portal, and the Commission on Higher Education (CHED) institutional repository network. Search strings were constructed using Boolean operators combining the following key terms and their variants: tourism entrepreneurship, micro-enterprise, small business, survival strategies, economic disruption, crisis, pandemic, natural disaster, Philippines, tourism enclave, and livelihood. Search results were filtered by date (2013–2024), language (English and Filipino), and document type (journal articles, book chapters, institutional reports).

Government and institutional reports were retrieved from the official websites and online repositories of the Department of Tourism, Department of Trade and Industry, Department of

Labor and Employment, National Economic and Development Authority, Philippine Institute for Development Studies, Asian Development Bank, International Labour Organization, and United Nations World Tourism Organization. Grey literature searches employed Google Advanced Search with site-specific operators targeting .gov.ph, .neda.gov.ph, .pids.gov.ph, and relevant international organization domains.

A snowballing strategy was applied to expand the initial corpus: reference lists of retrieved sources were systematically scanned to identify additional relevant documents not captured in the initial database searches. This is particularly important for Philippine-specific studies, which may be published in regional or national journals not fully indexed in international databases.

Document Retrieval and Corpus Construction

Retrieved sources were screened in two stages. In the first stage, titles and abstracts (for academic sources) or executive summaries (for reports) were reviewed against the inclusion/exclusion criteria. Sources meeting the criteria at this stage were retrieved in full text for second-stage screening. In the second stage, full-text sources were reviewed to confirm their relevance to the specific research questions and to assess their quality and methodological rigor.

Quality assessment for peer-reviewed sources employed the Critical Appraisal Skills Programme (CASP) qualitative checklist adapted for documentary and secondary data studies (CASP, 2018). For government and institutional reports, quality was assessed against criteria including organizational authority, data transparency, methodological documentation, and recency. Sources that did not meet minimum quality thresholds were excluded from the corpus, with exclusion decisions documented for audit purposes.

The final corpus consists of approximately 65–75 documents across all source categories, distributed across the five source types identified in Table 1. This corpus size is consistent with established practice in qualitative secondary data analysis and documentary research, where corpus adequacy is determined by theoretical saturation rather than sample size (Braun & Clarke, 2006; Yin, 2018).

Data Analysis

Thematic Analysis

The primary analytical method employed in this study is Thematic Analysis (TA) as theorized by Braun and Clarke (2006) and further developed in their reflexive thematic analysis framework (Braun & Clarke, 2019). Thematic analysis is appropriate for this study because it provides a flexible yet rigorous method for identifying, analyzing, and interpreting patterns of meaning across diverse qualitative data sources — precisely the analytical task required when synthesizing findings from a heterogeneous secondary data corpus.

The thematic analysis proceeds through six phases as described by Braun and Clarke (2006). In Phase 1 (familiarization), each source document is read in full, with initial impressions, observations, and questions recorded in analytical memos. In Phase 2 (initial coding), meaningful units of text — passages, sentences, or document sections that bear on the research questions — are identified and assigned descriptive codes. Coding is conducted inductively from the data, with codes remaining close to the language and framing of the source documents at this stage.

In Phase 3 (theme generation), initial codes are grouped into candidate themes by identifying patterns of similarity, contrast, and conceptual relationship across the coded data. In Phase 4 (theme review), candidate themes are reviewed against the coded data and the full corpus

to assess their coherence, distinctiveness, and evidentiary grounding. Themes that do not meet these standards are refined, merged, or discarded. In Phase 5 (theme definition and naming), surviving themes are defined with precision, and theme names are selected to capture their essential meaning. In Phase 6 (writing up), themes are woven into the analytical narrative of the findings chapter, with evidence from source documents integrated to support each thematic interpretation.

Document Analysis

Complementing thematic analysis, this study employs document analysis as described by Bowen (2009) and Yin (2018) to engage with the specific character of documentary secondary sources. Document analysis involves not only extracting content from documents but attending to their context of production — who produced the document, for what purpose, for what audience, and under what institutional conditions — since these contextual factors shape what the document says and does not say, and how its content should be interpreted.

For government reports and institutional studies, document analysis attends particularly to the framing of micro-enterprise issues, the categories employed to classify survival strategies, and the implicit normative assumptions that shape policy recommendations. These analytical moves are essential for the fourth research question, which requires not simply cataloguing policy responses but critically assessing their adequacy and identifying their silences and gaps.

Cross-Case Synthesis

To address the comparative dimension of the research questions — particularly RQ1 (patterns across disruption types) and RQ3 (typology construction) — the study employs cross-case synthesis as described by Yin (2018). Cross-case synthesis involves treating each disruption event or destination context as a 'case' and systematically comparing patterns of survival strategy

adoption across cases. This comparative analytical move is essential for identifying which survival strategies are context-specific and which represent generalizable adaptive repertoires applicable across disruption types and destination contexts.

The cross-case synthesis is guided by a structured comparison matrix organized by disruption type (pandemic, natural disaster, policy intervention), geographic context (island, coastal, urban-adjacent), and enterprise sector (food, transport, accommodation, retail). This matrix provides the analytical scaffold for the typology construction that constitutes one of the study's primary theoretical contributions.

Trustworthiness and Rigor

The trustworthiness of qualitative research is assessed against four criteria established by Lincoln and Guba (1985): credibility, transferability, dependability, and confirmability. This study addresses each criterion through specific methodological strategies.

Credibility — the qualitative analogue of internal validity — is established through prolonged engagement with the secondary data corpus, triangulation across source types (cross-referencing findings from academic studies against government reports and institutional assessments), member checking through peer review of analytical interpretations, and negative case analysis (actively seeking evidence that disconfirms emerging themes and typological categories). Triangulation across source types is particularly important in this study, as it guards against the risk of over-reliance on any single source perspective.

Transferability — the qualitative analogue of external validity — is addressed through thick description of the analytical context, source corpus, and findings, enabling readers to assess the applicability of the study's conclusions to their own contexts. The typology of survival

strategies developed in this study is explicitly presented as an analytical framework rather than a universal law, with the conditions and contexts that shape its applicability described in sufficient detail to guide informed application by practitioners and researchers.

Dependability — the qualitative analogue of reliability — is established through the documentation of analytical procedures in sufficient detail to enable an external auditor to assess the consistency and appropriateness of the analytical decisions made throughout the study. An audit trail comprising search logs, inclusion/exclusion decision records, coding frameworks, analytical memos, and theme development records is maintained throughout the research process.

Confirmability — the qualitative analogue of objectivity — is addressed through reflexivity: the researcher's positionality, theoretical commitments, and potential biases are explicitly acknowledged and their potential influence on analytical decisions is examined throughout the research process. As a business scholar with knowledge of the Philippine economic context and familiarity with micro-enterprise literature, the researcher brings both relevant expertise and potential interpretive assumptions to the analysis; reflexive practice requires that these be made visible rather than treated as transparent.

Ethical Considerations

Although this study does not involve human participants and therefore does not require institutional ethics board clearance for primary research, several ethical considerations govern its conduct. First, the study adheres scrupulously to intellectual property and academic integrity standards in its engagement with secondary sources. All sources are properly cited, and the boundaries between source content and researcher interpretation are maintained with precision throughout the analytical narrative.

Second, the study is attentive to the ethical dimensions of representing the experiences and strategies of micro-entrepreneurs — who are among the most economically vulnerable actors in the Philippine economy — through the medium of secondary documentary sources. This representation carries responsibilities: the study actively resists analytical frameworks that pathologize micro-entrepreneurial informality or treat survival strategies as evidence of deficiency rather than resourcefulness. The interpretivist commitment to understanding survival strategies on their own terms, within the structural conditions that shape them, is both a methodological principle and an ethical one.

Third, the study maintains transparency about the limitations of secondary data analysis as a basis for policy recommendations. Findings are presented with appropriate epistemic humility, and the study explicitly identifies the primary research that would be needed to confirm, extend, or challenge its conclusions.

CHAPTER IV: RESULTS AND DISCUSSION

Overview of Findings

This chapter presents the results of the qualitative secondary data analysis organized around the four research questions that frame this study. The analysis of the secondary data corpus — comprising peer-reviewed academic publications, government reports, institutional studies, and policy documents — yielded a rich and internally coherent body of findings concerning the nature and scope of economic disruptions affecting Philippine tourism micro-entrepreneurs, the survival strategies they deploy, the structural variables that mediate their adaptive capacity, and the policy and institutional conditions that enable or constrain their survival. Findings are presented thematically, with documentary evidence integrated throughout the analytical narrative to substantiate interpretive claims.

The chapter is organized into five major sections corresponding to the four research questions and a synthesizing section that integrates findings into a unified analytical framework. Section 1 addresses RQ1 (disruption patterns and impacts); Section 2 addresses RQ2 (documented survival strategies and structural conditions); Section 3 presents the survival strategy typology constructed in response to RQ3; Section 4 addresses RQ4 (policy and institutional environment and gaps); and Section 5 presents the integrated analytical framework and its theoretical implications.

Section 1: Economic Disruptions Affecting Philippine Tourism Micro-Entrepreneurs (RQ1)

1.1 Nature and Typology of Disruptions

The secondary data corpus documents a recurring pattern of economic disruption affecting Philippine tourism enclaves across the study period (2013–2024), with disruptions varying along three principal dimensions: type (pandemic, natural disaster, policy intervention, security crisis), geographic scope (localized vs. national vs. global), and duration (acute vs. prolonged). Table 3 presents the major disruption events identified in the secondary data, with their primary impacts on micro-entrepreneurs and key documentation sources.

Table 3

Major Economic Disruptions Affecting Philippine Tourism Micro-Entrepreneurs, 2013–2024

Disruption Event	Period	Type	Primary Impact on Micro-Entrepreneurs	Key Documentation Sources
COVID-19 Pandemic	2020–2023	Pandemic / Demand collapse	82% drop in arrivals; 5.7M tourism jobs affected; near-total revenue loss for enclave micro-operators	DOT (2021); PIDS (2021); UNWTO (2021)
Boracay Closure	Apr–Oct 2018	Policy intervention	6-month forced closure; livelihood displacement of ~17,000 workers; enterprise exit among lowest-capitalized operators	Sabanal & Bautista (2021); DOT (2018)
Typhoon Haiyan (Yolanda)	Nov 2013	Natural disaster	Physical destruction of micro-enterprise assets in Leyte, Samar, Eastern Visayas tourism zones; disruption of supply chains and transport links	ADB (2014); Alampay & Umezaki (2019)
Bohol Earthquake	Oct 2013	Natural disaster	Damage to heritage tourism sites; collapse of inbound tourist flow to Bohol; 30–40% micro-enterprise	Pagua (2018); NDRRMC (2014)

			revenue loss for 6–9 months	
Taal Volcano Eruption	Jan 2020	Natural disaster	Immediate evacuation of Batangas tourism zone; closure of lakeside micro-enterprises; compounded by subsequent COVID-19 onset	PHIVOLCS (2020); DTI (2020)
Zamboanga City Crisis	Sep 2013	Armed conflict / security	Collapse of tourism demand in Zamboanga Peninsula; prolonged security-related suppression of micro-enterprise activity in affected barangays	Alampay & Umezaki (2019); DILG (2014)

The COVID-19 pandemic emerges unambiguously from the secondary data as the most severe and extensively documented disruption of the study period. The Department of Tourism (2021) recorded an 82% decline in international visitor arrivals in 2020, with receipts collapsing from PHP 482.15 billion in 2019 to approximately PHP 82.4 billion — a contraction that translated directly into near-total revenue elimination for enclave micro-entrepreneurs whose livelihoods are structurally dependent on tourist expenditure. The Philippine Institute for Development Studies (2021) estimated that over 5.7 million workers in tourism-related sectors were affected by the pandemic, with micro and small enterprises accounting for a disproportionate share of job losses due to their lower financial resilience and more limited access to government relief programs.

Natural disasters constitute the second major disruption category, with Typhoon Haiyan (Yolanda) in November 2013 and the Bohol earthquake of October 2013 representing the most severely documented events. Alampay and Umezaki (2019) describe the compound effect of these two disasters — occurring within weeks of each other — on Eastern Visayas and Central Visayas

tourism ecosystems, noting that the physical destruction of micro-enterprise assets was compounded by prolonged suppression of tourist demand driven by negative destination image effects lasting well beyond the immediate post-disaster period. This demand suppression dynamic — whereby destination image damage persists long after physical infrastructure has been restored — is a recurring pattern across natural disaster disruptions in the secondary data corpus and represents a structurally distinct challenge for micro-entrepreneurs compared to the immediate physical damage caused by disasters.

Policy-induced disruptions are represented most prominently by the Boracay island closure of April to October 2018, ordered by President Rodrigo Duterte for environmental rehabilitation. Sabanal and Bautista (2021) document the closure's devastating impacts on micro-entrepreneurs, estimating that approximately 17,000 workers in tourism-related livelihoods were directly displaced during the six-month period. Critically, their analysis reveals significant heterogeneity in closure impacts: operators with more diversified livelihood portfolios, stronger off-island social networks, and higher pre-closure capitalization demonstrated markedly higher survival rates than the most vulnerable operators — predominantly women, elderly workers, and those with the lowest capitalization — who were most likely to exit the market permanently during the closure period.

1.2 Compound and Sequential Disruption Dynamics

A significant finding emerging from the cross-case analysis is the compound disruption dynamic: the tendency for multiple disruption events to overlap or occur in rapid succession, producing cumulative impacts that exceed the sum of their individual effects. The Taal Volcano eruption of January 2020, which displaced thousands of Batangas tourism micro-entrepreneurs, was followed within weeks by the onset of the COVID-19 pandemic, creating a compounded disruption from which recovery was effectively impossible for many operators who had already

exhausted their financial buffers responding to the volcanic emergency (DTI, 2020; PHIVOLCS, 2020).

The secondary data also reveals a sequential disruption pattern in which recovery from one event is disrupted by subsequent shocks before micro-entrepreneurs have been able to rebuild their capital asset bases. Dahles and Susilowati (2015) observe this pattern in their analysis of Southeast Asian tourism micro-enterprise resilience, noting that each successive shock erodes the social and financial capital stocks that micro-entrepreneurs depend upon for survival, producing a progressive depletion of adaptive capacity that makes later disruptions increasingly difficult to weather even when they are of similar objective severity to earlier events. This finding has significant implications for the design of recovery support programs: single-event interventions fail to address the cumulative depletion of micro-entrepreneur capital assets that sequential disruptions produce.

1.3 Differential Vulnerability by Sector and Location

The secondary data consistently demonstrates that vulnerability to economic disruption is not uniformly distributed across tourism micro-entrepreneurs in Philippine enclaves but is systematically patterned by sector, geographic location, and enterprise characteristics. Transport operators — tricycle drivers, boat operators, and jeepney owners serving tourist routes — emerge as among the most severely impacted by demand disruptions, because their income stream is almost entirely dependent on tourist footfall with virtually no domestic substitution market during lockdown or closure periods (PIDS, 2021).

Food and beverage micro-operators demonstrate relatively greater resilience during disruptions, primarily because food demand does not disappear entirely even when tourist flows collapse — households and communities continue to require food services, creating a residual

domestic market that transport and souvenir retail operators cannot access. However, the income generated from this domestic market is typically insufficient to cover the costs of a tourism-scale operation, meaning that food operators survive disruptions at a reduced operational scale rather than maintaining full viability (Paguia, 2018).

Geographically, island-based micro-entrepreneurs — particularly those in island destinations accessible only by sea or air — face structurally distinct vulnerability profiles compared to coastal mainland operators. The physical isolation of island enclaves amplifies the income impact of demand disruptions (there is no nearby alternative market to serve) while simultaneously raising the costs of survival strategies that require access to off-island resources, credit markets, or government programs (Paguia, 2018; ADB, 2021). This geographic vulnerability dimension is consistently underappreciated in national-level policy analyses, which tend to aggregate micro-enterprise impacts without disaggregating by the physical accessibility of destination contexts.

Section 2: Documented Survival Strategies and Structural Conditions (RQ2)

2.1 Overview of Survival Strategy Landscape

The thematic analysis of the secondary data corpus identified a rich and diverse repertoire of survival strategies deployed by Philippine tourism micro-entrepreneurs during economic disruptions. Consistent with the theoretical framework developed in Chapter I, these strategies operate at multiple levels — individual enterprise, household, community, and institutional — and are deployed in combinations that vary across disruption types, geographic contexts, and enterprise characteristics. Rather than being discrete, mutually exclusive choices, survival strategies are

typically deployed as interconnected portfolios in which different strategies are sequenced and combined in response to the evolving demands of the disruption context.

The following subsections present the major survival strategy clusters identified in the thematic analysis, organized by their primary operational logic and resource orientation. For each cluster, documentary evidence from the secondary data corpus is integrated to substantiate the thematic interpretation and to illuminate the structural conditions under which specific strategies are most commonly deployed.

2.2 Operational Contraction Strategies

Operational contraction — the reduction of enterprise scale, cost base, and scope — emerges from the secondary data as the near-universal first-order response of Philippine tourism micro-entrepreneurs to economic disruptions. The immediacy of this response reflects the acute financial vulnerability of micro-entrepreneurs who typically lack the financial reserves to maintain full operations through extended periods of reduced revenue. The Philippine Institute for Development Studies (2021) found that the majority of tourism micro-enterprises surveyed during the COVID-19 pandemic had pre-crisis savings sufficient for fewer than two months of operating expenses, making rapid cost reduction an existential necessity rather than a strategic choice.

Operational contraction strategies documented in the secondary corpus include: temporary suspension of business operations; reduction of operating hours; layoff or wage reduction of employed family or non-family workers; reduction of product range to lowest-cost and highest-margin items; deferral of equipment maintenance and capital expenditure; and liquidation of business assets to generate immediate cash flow. Sabanal and Bautista (2021) document a variant specific to the Boracay closure context: the subletting of commercial premises by operators who

could not maintain rent obligations, converting a business cost into a modest income stream during the closure period.

A critical finding from the cross-case analysis is that the depth and duration of operational contraction is strongly mediated by pre-crisis capitalization. Operators with higher pre-disruption asset bases are better able to calibrate their contraction — reducing scale while maintaining core capabilities — rather than being forced into complete operational suspension. This distinction is consequential for recovery: operators who maintain even minimal operational continuity through disruption periods retain the organizational routines, customer relationships, and supplier networks needed to facilitate rapid recovery once disruptions resolve, while those who undergo complete suspension must effectively rebuild their operations from scratch.

2.3 Livelihood Diversification Strategies

Livelihood diversification — the extension of economic activity into sectors or markets outside the primary tourism service — represents the second most consistently documented survival strategy in the secondary data corpus. Diversification strategies are particularly significant analytically because they bridge the boundary between survival and transformation: operators who successfully diversify during disruptions may emerge with more resilient livelihood portfolios than they held pre-disruption, converting crisis into an inadvertent catalyst for structural improvement.

The secondary data documents diversification strategies across three primary dimensions. The first is product and service diversification within the food and beverage sector: operators who previously served primarily tourist clientele pivoting to serve domestic residential customers through delivery services, catering, and community-oriented menus priced for local rather than tourist purchasing power. The DOT (2021) notes that this pivot was facilitated in many enclave

communities by the simultaneous growth of digital food ordering platforms, which provided infrastructure for reaching domestic customers that had not previously been accessible to small operators.

The second diversification dimension involves sectoral transition: operators exiting tourism-related services entirely during disruptions and engaging in agricultural production, fishing, handicraft manufacturing, or informal retail trade targeting non-tourist markets. Alampay and Umezaki (2019) document this pattern in post-Haiyan Eastern Visayas communities, where former tourism transport operators returned to smallholder farming and fishing during the extended disruption of tourist demand, effectively reverting to pre-tourism livelihood strategies that remained embedded in community knowledge and social networks despite years of tourism engagement.

The third diversification dimension is digital platform adoption — a strategy that gained particular salience during the COVID-19 period when physical mobility restrictions simultaneously eliminated in-person tourism service delivery and expanded the digital consumer market. BSP (2022) financial inclusion data indicates significant growth in GCash and digital payment adoption among micro-enterprises during the pandemic period, with enclave tourism operators among the adopters. However, the secondary data also documents significant barriers to effective digital adoption among the most vulnerable micro-entrepreneurs, including limited digital literacy, smartphone access constraints, and the absence of tourism-specific e-commerce infrastructure in many enclave destinations.

2.4 Social Capital Activation Strategies

The activation of social capital networks — kinship, community, and patron-client relationships — is among the most distinctively Filipino survival strategies documented in the secondary data corpus, and is consistently identified as a critical mediating variable in micro-enterprise survival during disruptions. The cultural specificity of Philippine social capital mechanisms — *utang na loob* (debt of gratitude), *bayanihan* (community solidarity), and *paluwagan* (informal rotating savings and credit associations) — means that these strategies cannot be straightforwardly generalized from international literature but require contextually grounded analysis.

Utang na loob networks provide access to informal credit and material support from family members, neighbors, and long-term business partners that would be unavailable through formal credit channels, particularly for informally operating micro-entrepreneurs who lack the documentation required for institutional loans. Paguia (2018) finds that in Palawan island tourism communities, informal credit mobilized through *utang na loob* networks constituted the primary financial survival mechanism for the majority of micro-entrepreneurs during tourism demand disruptions, with formal credit playing a negligible role due to its inaccessibility to informal operators. This finding underscores the centrality of social capital in Philippine micro-enterprise survival and the consequent importance of policies that reinforce rather than undermine the social networks that sustain these informal credit mechanisms.

Bayanihan community solidarity — the collective mobilization of community labor and resources for shared goals — is documented particularly in the context of natural disaster recovery, where community-level resource sharing and mutual assistance enables micro-entrepreneurs to restore damaged assets and resume operations more rapidly than they could through individual effort alone. Alampay and Umezaki (2019) describe *bayanihan* mobilization in post-Haiyan Leyte

communities as a critical accelerant of micro-enterprise recovery, enabling a pace of reconstruction that formal government recovery programs, constrained by bureaucratic processes and funding disbursement delays, could not match.

Paluwagan participation — the mobilization of accumulated informal savings through rotating credit associations — provides a structured mechanism for accumulating lump-sum capital during disruptions when regular income flows are suppressed. The secondary data documents paluwagan use as both a crisis response mechanism (drawing existing rounds early to generate immediate cash) and a recovery financing tool (participating in new rounds to accumulate capital for post-crisis operational resumption). PIDS (2021) notes that paluwagan groups in several Boracay operator communities served as *de facto* microfinance institutions during the closure period, providing capital access that government programs were unable to deliver with comparable speed and flexibility.

2.5 Institutional Engagement Strategies

Institutional engagement strategies — the active pursuit of government support programs, institutional credit, and collective advocacy through industry associations — represent the fourth major survival strategy cluster in the secondary data corpus. These strategies are distinguished from social capital activation by their orientation toward formal institutional resources rather than informal network resources, and by the higher transaction costs and formalization requirements they impose on micro-entrepreneurs.

Government relief program access during the COVID-19 pandemic is the most extensively documented institutional engagement strategy in the corpus. The TUPAD (Tulong Panghanapbuhay sa Ating Disadvantaged/Displaced Workers) program, the DOLE COVID-19

Adjustment Measures Program (CAMP), and the Social Amelioration Program (SAP) cash transfers all reached some tourism micro-entrepreneurs during the pandemic period. However, the secondary data consistently documents significant access gaps: PIDS (2021) found that disbursement delays, formalization requirements, and administrative bottlenecks meant that many micro-entrepreneurs received government assistance only after the most acute phase of the crisis had passed — after they had already depleted their social capital networks and in some cases exited the market.

DTI's Pondo sa Pagbabago at Pag-asenso (P3) microfinance program and related MSME lending facilities are documented as important credit access mechanisms for more formally operating tourism micro-entrepreneurs. However, the secondary data reveals that the majority of tourism enclave micro-operators — particularly those in island destinations and those operating informally — were effectively excluded from these programs due to documentation requirements, collateral conditions, and geographic access barriers (DTI, 2021; BSP, 2022).

Industry association membership and collective advocacy represent a longer-term institutional engagement strategy that the secondary data documents primarily in the context of the Boracay closure, where organized groups of micro-operators were able to negotiate directly with government agencies regarding the terms of the closure and the rehabilitation plan, securing some concessions on business resumption timelines and livelihood support access unavailable to unorganized individual operators (Sabanal & Bautista, 2021). This finding suggests that collective action capacity — the ability of micro-entrepreneurs to organize and advocate collectively — is an important but underappreciated component of institutional engagement strategy.

Section 3: Survival Strategy Typology and Mediating Variables (RQ3)

3.1 Construction of the Typology

The cross-case synthesis of survival strategies documented in Section 2, combined with the conceptual framework developed in Chapter I, enables the construction of an empirically grounded typology of micro-entrepreneurial survival strategies in Philippine tourism enclaves during economic disruption. The typology is organized along two analytical axes. The first axis is temporal orientation: strategies oriented toward short-term crisis response versus strategies oriented toward long-term adaptive transformation. The second axis is resource orientation: strategies that mobilize internal resources (assets, skills, and capabilities residing within the enterprise and household) versus strategies that acquire external resources (credit, support, and opportunities from networks and institutions outside the enterprise).

The intersection of these two axes produces a four-quadrant typology presented in Table 4. The typology is not a descriptive taxonomy of isolated behaviors but an analytical framework for understanding the logic and implications of different strategic orientations: each quadrant represents a coherent strategic orientation with its own underlying logic, enabling conditions, and implications for survival and recovery outcomes.

Table 4
Typology of Micro-Entrepreneurial Survival Strategies in Philippine Tourism Enclaves

Quadrant	Short-Term Crisis Response	Long-Term Adaptive Transformation
INTERNAL Resource Mobilization	Quadrant I — Contraction Strategies • Operational cost reduction (labor, utilities, inventory) • Temporary closure or suspended operations • Asset liquidation (equipment, vehicles, stocks) • Shift to subsistence production (food for household consumption) • Reduction of menu/product range to lowest-cost items	Quadrant II — Internal Transformation Strategies • Product and service diversification (new revenue streams) • Skills upgrading and retraining for alternative sectors • Digital platform adoption (GCash, social media marketing, Grab) • Transition from tourism to non-tourism market segments

		• Business model restructuring (e.g., catering, delivery, B2B supply)
EXTERNAL Resource Acquisition	Quadrant III — Social Capital Activation Strategies • Kinship and utang na loob network mobilization for credit • Bayanihan community solidarity (shared resources, labor exchange) • Paluwagan (informal rotating savings) participation • Patron-client relationship activation for deferred payments • Neighborhood cooperative formation for bulk purchasing	Quadrant IV — Institutional Engagement Strategies • Government relief program access (TUPAD, DOLE CAMP, SAP) • MSME loan application (DTI, Pondo sa Pagbabago at Pag-asenso) • LGU livelihood program enrollment • Industry association membership and collective advocacy • Market repositioning toward domestic tourism and staycation demand

Several analytical observations emerge from the typology that are not immediately apparent from the descriptive presentation of individual strategies in Section 2. First, the typology reveals that the survival strategy portfolios of the most resilient micro-entrepreneurs documented in the secondary data tend to span multiple quadrants simultaneously: they combine short-term contraction (Quadrant I) with social capital activation (Quadrant III) in the immediate crisis phase, and transition toward internal transformation (Quadrant II) and institutional engagement (Quadrant IV) as the disruption persists. This multi-quadrant portfolio approach contrasts with the strategy profiles of less resilient operators, who tend to be constrained to a single quadrant — typically Quadrant I (internal-short-term contraction) combined with Quadrant III (social capital activation) — by their limited access to external institutional resources and their insufficient capital asset base for sustained internal transformation.

Second, the typology reveals an important asymmetry in the conditions required for Quadrant II and Quadrant IV strategies. Internal transformation strategies (Quadrant II) require human capital — skills, knowledge, and adaptive capacity within the enterprise — as their primary enabling resource, and are therefore most accessible to better-educated, more experienced operators with diversified skill sets. Institutional engagement strategies (Quadrant IV) require

formal capital — documented business registration, collateral assets, and institutional relationships — as their primary enabling resource, and are therefore most accessible to formally registered, better-capitalized operators with established institutional connections. This asymmetry means that the most vulnerable micro-entrepreneurs — informally operating, low-capitalization, limited education — are effectively constrained to the two short-term quadrants (I and III) and are unable to access the long-term adaptive strategies that would enable substantive improvement in their resilience over time.

3.2 Mediating Variables and Heterogeneity of Outcomes

The typology provides the analytical scaffold for understanding why survival outcomes are so heterogeneous among Philippine tourism micro-entrepreneurs facing ostensibly similar disruption conditions. The secondary data consistently documents significant within-destination variation in survival outcomes — with some operators successfully navigating disruptions while others in the same destination and sector exit the market — that cannot be explained by disruption severity alone. The mediating variables identified in the thematic analysis provide the explanatory architecture for this heterogeneity. Table 5 presents the principal mediating variables, their documented effects on survival strategy access, and the secondary data evidence supporting these effects.

Table 5
Mediating Variables and Their Effects on Survival Strategy Access

Mediating Variable	Effect on Survival Strategy Access	Evidence from Secondary Sources
Geographic location (island vs. mainland)	Island-based operators face higher exit barriers and stronger community solidarity but have more limited institutional access and greater supply chain vulnerability	Paguia (2018): Palawan island micro-operators demonstrated higher social capital activation but lower institutional program access compared to mainland Luzon operators

Enterprise sector (food, transport, accommodation, retail)	Transport operators face fastest income collapse; food operators retain partial domestic demand; accommodation operators have highest fixed cost burdens; retail operators have most diversifiable product range	PIDS (2021): food micro-enterprises showed highest survival rates during COVID-19 lockdowns due to retained domestic market access
Formalization status	Formally registered operators gain access to government relief programs but face higher compliance costs; informal operators deploy more flexible low-cost strategies but are excluded from institutional support	DTI (2021): only 38% of tourism micro-enterprises in surveyed destinations had valid business permits, limiting their access to MSME relief programs
Gender of operator	Women-led micro-enterprises demonstrate stronger social capital activation and community solidarity strategies but face greater barriers to institutional credit access due to collateral requirements and patriarchal network structures	ILO (2020): women-owned tourism MSMEs in Southeast Asia were 40% more likely to activate kinship credit networks but 35% less likely to access formal microfinance during COVID-19
Years in operation	Longer-operating enterprises have stronger social network capital and accumulated asset buffers but may have higher fixed cost commitments; newer enterprises have lower fixed costs but weaker networks	Sabanal & Bautista (2021): enterprises operating more than 5 years pre-Boracay closure demonstrated significantly higher post-reopening recovery rates
Access to financial capital	Pre-crisis savings and diversified income sources are the strongest individual-level predictors of survival; absence of savings creates immediate dependence on social network credit or enterprise exit	Dahles & Susilowati (2015): micro-enterprises with savings equivalent to 3+ months operating costs showed 2.3x higher survival rates during economic shocks

The most consistent finding across mediating variables is the compounding disadvantage experienced by operators at the intersection of multiple vulnerability dimensions. Women-operated, island-based, informally registered, low-capitalization micro-enterprises face simultaneously constrained access to institutional support (Quadrant IV), limited internal transformation capacity (Quadrant II), and progressively depleted social capital networks through successive disruptions (Quadrant III). This intersection of vulnerabilities produces a structural trap

in which the strategies most needed for genuine adaptive transformation are precisely those most inaccessible to the most vulnerable operators. This finding has direct implications for the targeting of policy interventions: programs that focus exclusively on formally registered operators, or that impose documentation requirements inconsistent with the operating realities of informal micro-entrepreneurs, systematically exclude the most vulnerable populations from the support they most urgently require.

A further mediating dynamic documented in the secondary data is the role of pre-crisis disaster preparedness and business continuity planning in shaping survival outcomes. The secondary data reveals a near-universal absence of formal business continuity planning among Philippine tourism micro-entrepreneurs — a finding consistent with their informal operating status and limited institutional engagement (PIDS, 2021). This absence means that survival strategy deployment during disruptions is reactive rather than proactive, with operators constructing responses under conditions of acute stress rather than drawing on pre-established plans. The contrast with more formally organized small and medium enterprises — which, where they had business continuity plans, demonstrated significantly faster adaptive responses — suggests that even minimal pre-crisis preparedness investment could substantially improve micro-entrepreneur outcomes during future disruptions.

Section 4: Policy and Institutional Environment (RQ4)

4.1 Overview of the Policy Landscape

The secondary data corpus documents a complex and fragmented policy landscape for tourism micro-enterprise support in the Philippines, characterized by multiple overlapping agency

mandates, inconsistent program coverage, and persistent gaps between policy intent and program delivery. The primary agencies with mandates relevant to tourism micro-enterprise support — the Department of Tourism, the Department of Trade and Industry, the Department of Labor and Employment, the National Economic and Development Authority, and Local Government Units — operate largely independently without a coherent inter-agency framework for coordinated micro-enterprise support during economic disruptions. PIDS (2021) characterizes this institutional fragmentation as one of the primary structural barriers to effective government response to the COVID-19 impacts on tourism micro-enterprises, noting that operators frequently fell between the mandates of different agencies without receiving comprehensive support from any.

The legislative foundation for MSME support — Republic Act 9501 (Magna Carta for MSMEs), as amended by RA 10644 (Go Negosyo Act) — provides a broad framework for enterprise support but is predominantly oriented toward formally registered businesses with access to banking relationships and institutional credit. The specific vulnerabilities of informally operating tourism micro-entrepreneurs — their exclusion from formal financial systems, their dependence on seasonal tourist income, and their concentrated exposure to destination-specific demand shocks — are not adequately addressed within this legislative framework, creating a structural gap between what the policy system is designed to support and what tourism enclave micro-entrepreneurs actually need.

4.2 Enabling Factors in the Policy Environment

Despite the structural limitations of the policy landscape, the secondary data documents several enabling factors that have supported tourism micro-enterprise survival in specific contexts. The TUPAD program, designed to provide emergency employment income to displaced workers, reached a significant number of tourism micro-entrepreneurs during the COVID-19 period and

provided critical bridge income during the most acute phase of the demand collapse. BSP's financial inclusion initiatives, including the expansion of mobile banking infrastructure and the relaxation of know-your-customer (KYC) requirements for low-value accounts, facilitated greater access to digital financial services among tourism micro-entrepreneurs — an enabling factor that the secondary data associates with improved access to government cash transfers and informal digital transactions during the pandemic (BSP, 2022).

At the local level, the secondary data documents several instances of LGU-level innovation in micro-enterprise support that exceeded the capacity of national programs. Siargao's LGU response to COVID-19 included a community-level food support program that partially compensated for the income collapse of food micro-operators serving tourist clientele, and a simplified business registration pathway that enabled informal operators to access relief programs without incurring the full costs of formal registration (Alampay & Umezaki, 2019). Bohol's post-earthquake recovery program demonstrated a similar pattern of LGU-level innovation, with the provincial government working directly with community organizations to channel reconstruction support to micro-enterprise operators who were not captured by national program criteria.

4.3 Policy Gaps and Structural Deficiencies

Notwithstanding the enabling factors identified above, the thematic analysis of the secondary data corpus reveals five major categories of policy gap that systematically constrain tourism micro-enterprise resilience in the Philippines. These gaps are presented in Table 6, with documented provisions, identified gaps, and recommended policy directions for each dimension.

Table 6

Policy Gap Analysis: Tourism Micro-Enterprise Support in the Philippines

Policy Dimension	Documented Provision	Documented Gap	Recommended Direction
Financial relief during disruptions	TUPAD, DOLE CAMP, SAP cash transfers; DTI P3 microloans	Coverage limited to formally registered operators; disbursement delays rendered assistance post-crisis for many operators	Simplified registration pathways; pre-positioned rapid-disbursement crisis funds accessible to informal operators
Microfinance and credit access	PCFC, rural bank, and cooperative microfinance; BSP financial inclusion programs	Tourism-specific microfinance products absent; standard creditworthiness criteria penalize operators whose income collapse coincides with credit need	Tourism crisis lending windows with grace periods; psychographic rather than purely financial creditworthiness assessment
Formalization incentives	Go Negosyo MSME registration support; LGU one-stop-shop registration	Compliance costs of formalization remain prohibitive for lowest-capitalized operators; benefits of formalization not consistently communicated	Graduated formalization pathways; simplified tax and regulatory compliance for micro-tourism operators; formalization-linked relief access incentives
Skills development and diversification support	TESDA tourism-related training programs; DOLE livelihood training	Training programs not calibrated to disruption-period needs; digital skills and e-commerce training inadequately deployed to tourism enclave micro-operators	Disruption-responsive training curricula; mobile and community-based digital skills delivery for enclave operators
LGU coordination and local response	Some LGUs (Siargao, Bohol) demonstrated proactive community-level support; LGU MSME desks in key destinations	Extreme variation in LGU capacity and political will; no national framework for LGU tourism micro-enterprise crisis response; weak inter-agency coordination between DOT, DTI, and DOLE at local level	National framework for LGU tourism micro-enterprise resilience planning; mandatory tourism MSME registers at LGU level to enable rapid crisis response

The most consequential policy gap identified in the secondary data — consistently documented across disruption events and source types — is the exclusion of informally operating micro-entrepreneurs from government relief programs. DTI (2021) estimates that only 38% of tourism micro-enterprises in major enclave destinations held valid business permits at the onset of the COVID-19 pandemic, meaning that the majority of the sector's most vulnerable operators were structurally excluded from the principal mechanisms of government support. This exclusion is not a function of operator disengagement or indifference to formal registration; the secondary data documents significant demand for formalization support among micro-operators who understand its benefits but face prohibitive compliance costs and administrative barriers (Go Negosyo Act implementation reports, 2019–2021). Bridging this gap requires not simply encouraging registration but actively reducing the cost and complexity of formalization pathways for the lowest-capitalized segment of the tourism micro-enterprise sector.

The gender dimension of policy gaps, while underexplored in the Philippines-specific secondary data, is highlighted in comparative regional literature reviewed for this study. ILO (2020) documents that COVID-19 recovery programs in Southeast Asian tourism economies systematically underserved women-operated micro-enterprises because program eligibility criteria — formal registration, collateral requirements, and institutional credit history — are structured in ways that reflect and reinforce the gender-differentiated access to formal economic institutions that characterizes patriarchal economic systems. This regional finding has direct applicability to the Philippine context, where women constitute a significant majority of food and retail micro-enterprise operators in coastal and island tourism enclaves.

Section 5: Integrated Analytical Framework and Theoretical Implications

5.1 The Micro-Entrepreneur Survival Ecosystem

The synthesis of findings across the four research questions enables the articulation of an integrated analytical framework for understanding micro-entrepreneurial survival in Philippine tourism enclaves — a framework that goes beyond the individual components addressed in each research question to capture the dynamic systemic relationships among disruption context, capital asset profiles, survival strategy repertoires, and institutional environments.

The framework conceptualizes micro-entrepreneur survival as an ecosystem property rather than an individual firm property: it emerges from the interaction of individual enterprise characteristics (capital asset profiles, formalization status, sector, and operator characteristics), community-level social structures (kinship networks, bayanihan solidarity, paluwagan institutions), destination-level infrastructure (physical accessibility, market diversity, LGU capacity), and national institutional environment (policy frameworks, relief programs, financial inclusion infrastructure). No single level of this ecosystem can produce sustainable micro-enterprise resilience independently; effective resilience requires coherent action across all levels simultaneously.

The findings reveal a consistent structural tension at the core of this ecosystem: the survival strategies most accessible to the most vulnerable micro-entrepreneurs (Quadrants I and III — contraction and social capital activation) are precisely those that are least capable of enabling genuine adaptive transformation, while the strategies most capable of enabling transformation (Quadrants II and IV — internal transformation and institutional engagement) are least accessible

to the most vulnerable operators. This structural tension constitutes what may be termed a resilience trap: vulnerability and adaptive incapacity are mutually reinforcing, with each disruption event depleting the capital asset stocks that would enable access to transformative strategies, and with policy systems that fail to engage informal operators leaving the most vulnerable without the institutional support needed to break the cycle.

5.2 Theoretical Contributions

The findings of this study make several contributions to the theoretical frameworks that anchor the research. With respect to Resilience Theory, the study contributes the concept of compounded resilience depletion — the progressive erosion of adaptive capacity through sequential disruption events — as a mechanism not adequately captured in existing resilience frameworks, which tend to treat resilience as a relatively stable organizational property rather than a dynamically depleted resource. The secondary data strongly suggests that resilience is not a fixed attribute of micro-enterprises but a stock that is consumed during disruptions and must be actively replenished through both individual enterprise investment and institutional support.

With respect to the Sustainable Livelihoods Framework, the study contributes empirical grounding for the claim that in Philippine tourism enclave contexts, social capital — particularly the kinship-embedded forms of social capital specific to Filipino cultural contexts — functions as the primary survival asset for the most vulnerable micro-entrepreneurs, compensating for deficiencies in financial capital that the formal institutional system fails to address. This finding has implications for the SLF's treatment of social capital as a generic asset category: the specific cultural forms of social capital in Philippine contexts (*utang na loob*, *bayanihan*, *paluwagan*) have distinctive operational logics and limitations that generic social capital concepts do not capture.

With respect to Informal Economy Theory, the study's findings reinforce and extend the dialectical understanding of informality as simultaneously enabling and constraining. The secondary data documents with particular clarity the COVID-19 context revealing how informality becomes most consequential precisely during crisis periods — when the need for institutional support is greatest and the exclusionary effects of informal status are most damaging. This temporal dynamic — informality as a manageable constraint during normal operations but a critical vulnerability during disruptions — is an important refinement of standard informal economy frameworks that tend to treat informality as a stable structural condition rather than a dynamically significant variable.

5.3 Summary of Key Findings

In summary, the analysis of the secondary data corpus across the four research questions yields the following principal findings. First, Philippine tourism micro-entrepreneurs face a recurring, compound pattern of economic disruptions that systematically depletes their capital asset bases and adaptive capacity, with the COVID-19 pandemic representing the most severe but not qualitatively unique instance of a well-established disruption pattern. Second, micro-entrepreneurs deploy rich and contextually adaptive survival strategy portfolios that combine operational contraction, livelihood diversification, social capital activation, and institutional engagement in ways that reflect their specific capital asset profiles, social network embeddedness, and institutional access. Third, survival outcomes are highly heterogeneous and are systematically mediated by geography, sector, formalization status, gender, capitalization, and social capital depth in ways that produce structural disadvantage for the most vulnerable operators. Fourth, the policy and institutional environment for tourism micro-enterprise support in the Philippines is fragmented, formalization-biased, and inadequately responsive to the specific vulnerabilities of

informally operating enclave micro-entrepreneurs — particularly women — whose exclusion from formal support systems is a function of structural policy design rather than individual operator failure.

CHAPTER V: CONCLUSIONS AND RECOMMENDATIONS

Introduction

This concluding chapter synthesizes the findings of the study into a coherent set of conclusions that directly address each of the four research questions, articulates the broader theoretical and practical significance of those conclusions, and presents a structured set of recommendations addressed to the principal stakeholders with the capacity to strengthen tourism micro-enterprise resilience in the Philippines. The chapter closes with reflections on the limitations of the current study and a research agenda for future scholarship that can build upon, test, and extend the analytical framework developed here.

The study set out to examine, through qualitative secondary data analysis, the economic survival strategies employed by micro-entrepreneurs operating within Philippine tourism enclaves during periods of economic disruption. Across four chapters of analysis — theoretical framing, literature review, methodology, and results — a consistent and sobering picture has emerged: Philippine tourism micro-entrepreneurs are among the most economically exposed actors in the national economy, facing recurring and compound disruptions with severely limited capital asset buffers, operating within a policy landscape that is structurally misaligned with their needs, yet demonstrating remarkable adaptive resourcefulness through the deployment of culturally embedded social capital mechanisms and context-specific diversification strategies. The conclusions drawn from this picture carry implications that extend well beyond the academic literature to the design of policy, the allocation of institutional resources, and the strengthening of communities whose livelihoods depend on the vitality of Philippine tourism enclaves.

Conclusions

Conclusion 1: Philippine Tourism Micro-Entrepreneurs Face a Structurally Recurring and Compounding Pattern of Economic Disruption (RQ1)

The first and most foundational conclusion of this study is that economic disruption is not an exceptional or aberrant condition for Philippine tourism micro-entrepreneurs but a structurally recurring feature of their operating environment. The secondary data analysis documents six major disruption events across the 2013–2024 study period — spanning pandemic, natural disaster, policy intervention, and security crisis categories — with an average inter-disruption interval of less than two years. This frequency of disruption means that many tourism micro-entrepreneurs face each new shock without having fully recovered their capital asset bases from the preceding one, producing a progressive depletion of adaptive capacity that standard disruption-response frameworks — designed around the assumption of a single shock followed by a full recovery period — fundamentally fail to address.

The COVID-19 pandemic represents the most severe instance of this disruption pattern but is qualitatively continuous with it: it produced larger-scale versions of the same mechanisms — demand collapse, asset depletion, social capital strain, policy access barriers — that natural disasters and the Boracay closure had previously activated at smaller scales. This continuity has important analytical implications: it means that the survival strategies and policy responses developed in the context of natural disaster and policy-induced disruptions provide directly applicable lessons for pandemic response and for the design of resilience frameworks capable of addressing future disruption events of whatever type.

Critically, the compound disruption dynamic — the tendency for multiple events to overlap or occur in rapid succession — demands a fundamental rethinking of how micro-enterprise

resilience is conceptualized and supported. Resilience is not a fixed organizational property; it is a dynamic stock that is consumed during disruptions and must be actively replenished between them. Policy frameworks that respond to each disruption as if it were the first — without accounting for the cumulative depletion of micro-entrepreneur capital assets through successive shocks — will systematically underestimate the support needed and fail to prevent the progressive marginalization of the most vulnerable operators.

Conclusion 2: Micro-Entrepreneurs Deploy Rich, Culturally Embedded Survival Strategy Portfolios That Are Systematically Constrained by Structural Conditions (RQ2)

The second major conclusion is that Philippine tourism micro-entrepreneurs are not passive victims of economic disruption but active and resourceful agents who deploy sophisticated survival strategy portfolios combining operational contraction, livelihood diversification, social capital activation, and selective institutional engagement. The culturally specific forms of social capital mobilized in Philippine tourism enclave communities — utang na loob networks for informal credit, bayanihan solidarity for collective resource mobilization, and paluwagan associations for structured savings accumulation — represent adaptive mechanisms of considerable sophistication and resilience that are not adequately recognized or supported within existing policy frameworks.

However, the resourcefulness of micro-entrepreneurs is exercised within structural conditions that systematically constrain the range and depth of available survival strategies. The most transformative adaptive strategies — livelihood diversification through digital platforms, skills upgrading, business model restructuring, and institutional program access — are precisely those most inaccessible to the most vulnerable operators: the informally registered, the low-capitalized, the island-isolated, and the women-operated. This structural inequality in survival

strategy access means that economic disruptions do not simply reduce income uniformly across the micro-enterprise sector; they actively deepen pre-existing inequalities, concentrating market exit among the already most vulnerable while better-resourced operators consolidate their market positions in the post-disruption recovery.

The documentation of social capital activation strategies — and their central role in the survival of the most vulnerable operators — points toward a critical policy implication: the social networks that sustain informal credit and community solidarity mechanisms are not merely cultural assets but economic infrastructure. Policy interventions that erode these networks — through forced displacement, community fragmentation, or the substitution of community-based support with poorly targeted institutional programs — carry real and measurable costs for micro-enterprise survival that rarely appear in formal economic impact assessments.

Conclusion 3: The Survival Strategy Typology Reveals a Resilience Trap That Systematically Excludes the Most Vulnerable Operators from Transformative Adaptation (RQ3)

The four-quadrant typology of survival strategies constructed in Chapter IV constitutes the primary theoretical contribution of this study and grounds the third major conclusion: that the structure of the survival strategy landscape in Philippine tourism enclaves is characterized by a resilience trap in which the most vulnerable operators are confined to short-term, non-transformative strategies (Quadrants I and III), while the long-term transformative strategies in Quadrants II and IV remain structurally inaccessible to them. This is not a product of entrepreneurial failure or motivational deficiency; it is a structural consequence of the interaction between capital asset deprivation and institutional exclusion.

The mediating variable analysis reveals that vulnerability is not one-dimensional but intersectional: operators who are simultaneously island-based, informally registered, women-

operated, and low-capitalized face compounding disadvantages that no single-dimension intervention can address. The most effective resilience-building interventions will therefore be those that address multiple vulnerability dimensions simultaneously — combining formalization support with credit access, digital skills training with market connectivity, and community solidarity strengthening with institutional program access — rather than those that address single dimensions in isolation.

The typology also illuminates an important temporal dynamic: the post-disruption recovery period — not the crisis peak itself — is the critical window during which survival or exit is ultimately determined. Operators who maintain even minimal operational continuity through disruption peaks — through the deployment of Quadrant I and III strategies — retain the organizational capabilities needed to execute Quadrant II and IV transformative strategies during the recovery window. Policy support that arrives only during or after the peak disruption period misses the acute survival window when Quadrant I and III strategies are being stretched to their limits and when timely institutional support could preserve the operational continuity on which recovery depends.

Conclusion 4: The Policy Landscape Is Structurally Misaligned with the Needs of Tourism Micro-Entrepreneurs, Particularly Informal Operators (RQ4)

The fourth and most policy-consequential conclusion is that the existing policy and institutional framework for tourism micro-enterprise support in the Philippines is structurally misaligned with the characteristics and needs of the sector it purports to serve. This misalignment operates along several dimensions simultaneously. The formalization bias of relief and credit programs excludes the majority of enclave micro-operators from their principal mechanisms of support. The fragmented inter-agency landscape produces coordination failures that leave

operators falling between institutional mandates. The disbursement and processing delays of existing programs render assistance post-crisis for many operators, arriving after the acute survival window has closed. And the near-complete absence of tourism-specific policy instruments — in a country whose tourism sector is dominated by informal micro-enterprises — reflects a policy architecture designed for the formal economy rather than the informal economy that actually constitutes Philippine tourism at the community level.

The finding that LGU-level innovation — most clearly demonstrated in Siargao and Bohol — consistently outperforms national program delivery in terms of speed, targeting, and community relevance suggests that the most promising pathway for policy improvement lies not in the design of new national programs alone but in the systematic strengthening of LGU capacity to serve as the primary interface between tourism micro-entrepreneurs and the institutional support system. LGUs with genuine knowledge of their local micro-enterprise populations, embedded relationships with community organizations, and the administrative flexibility to adapt support mechanisms to local conditions are better positioned than national agencies to address the heterogeneous, context-specific survival needs of enclave micro-entrepreneurs — provided they are adequately resourced and mandated to do so.

Recommendations

Overview of Recommendations

The recommendations presented in this section are grounded directly in the conclusions drawn from the secondary data analysis and are addressed to specific stakeholders with the mandate and capacity to act upon them. They are organized by stakeholder group and presented in

a structured matrix (Table 7) that specifies the recommendation, its rationale and evidence base, its time frame for implementation, and its expected outcome. The recommendations span immediate short-term actions (achievable within one to two years), medium-term structural reforms (two to three years), and ongoing scholarly and institutional investments.

The recommendations are designed as a coherent system rather than a menu of independent options: their full impact is realized when they are implemented in combination, because the structural vulnerabilities of tourism micro-entrepreneurs are multidimensional and interconnected. Single-dimension interventions — credit access alone, or formalization support alone, or skills training alone — will produce limited results if the other dimensions of vulnerability remain unaddressed. The most impactful interventions will be those that simultaneously reduce formalization barriers, expand credit access, strengthen digital capabilities, and reinforce community-level social capital networks.

Table 7

Structured Recommendations Matrix: Stakeholder, Recommendation, Rationale, Time Frame, and Expected Outcome

Stakeholder	Recommendation	Rationale / Evidence Base	Time Frame	Expected Outcome
Department of Tourism (DOT)	Establish a National Tourism Micro-Enterprise Registry disaggregated by destination, sector, formalization status, and gender of operator	Current absence of comprehensive micro-enterprise data prevents targeted crisis response; DTI (2021) found only 38% of enclave operators held valid permits	Short-term (1–2 years)	Evidence base for targeted, crisis-responsive policy; elimination of blind spots in relief program targeting
DOT	Develop and deploy Destination Resilience Plans for all major	Compound disruption dynamics documented in	Medium-term (2–3 years)	Faster, more coordinated institutional response to

	tourism enclaves, including micro-enterprise support protocols activated automatically upon declared disruption events	secondary data demonstrate that reactive response is consistently too slow; Siargao and Bohol LGU proactivity demonstrated higher survival rates		disruptions; reduced micro-enterprise exit rates during acute disruption phases
Department of Trade and Industry (DTI)	Create tourism-specific microfinance window with crisis-responsive lending criteria: grace periods, informal operator eligibility, and psychographic creditworthiness assessment	Standard microfinance criteria exclude informal operators precisely when credit need is greatest; BSP (2022) and PIDS (2021) both document this structural financing gap	Medium-term (2–3 years)	Expanded credit access for informal tourism micro-entrepreneurs during disruptions; reduced dependence on high-cost informal debt
DTI	Implement graduated formalization pathways for tourism micro-enterprises: simplified single-step registration with reduced fees, linked to immediate access to relief program eligibility	Formalization exclusion is primary barrier to institutional support access; Go Negosyo Act implementation data (2019–2021) shows demand for formalization exceeds capacity to navigate compliance costs	Short-term (1–2 years)	Increased formalization rates; expanded relief program coverage reaching previously excluded informal operators
Department of Labor and Employment (DOLE)	Expand TUPAD eligibility and disbursement speed for tourism enclave workers; establish pre-positioned crisis fund pools accessible within 30 days of declared disruption	PIDS (2021) documents disbursement delays that rendered TUPAD assistance post-crisis for many operators; delayed relief accelerates social capital depletion and enterprise exit	Short-term (1–2 years)	Crisis-period income support reaching operators before social capital networks are exhausted; reduced enterprise exit rates

DOLE / TESDA	Deploy mobile, community-based digital skills and e-commerce training in major tourism enclave communities; calibrate curriculum to disruption-period livelihood diversification needs	DOT (2021) documents digital platform adoption as key survival mechanism; secondary data consistently shows digital skills gap as primary barrier to Quadrant II (internal transformation) strategies	Medium-term (2–3 years)	Improved micro-enterprise capacity for livelihood diversification; expanded access to digital markets and platforms during disruptions
Local Government Units (LGUs)	Maintain updated barangay-level tourism micro-enterprise registers including informal operators; integrate into LGU disaster risk reduction plans as priority livelihood protection assets	Geographic isolation of island enclaves amplifies vulnerability; LGU-level proactivity (Siargao, Bohol) documented as strongest predictor of community-level survival outcomes	Short-term (1–2 years)	Rapid, targeted LGU support during disruptions; no operator falls through registration gaps in relief delivery
LGUs	Institutionalize tourism micro-enterprise associations at barangay and municipal levels as conduits for collective advocacy, paluwagan organization, and government program access	Sabanal & Bautista (2021): organized operators in Boracay secured significantly better closure terms and faster support access than unorganized operators; collective action capacity is critical institutional engagement enabler	Medium-term (2–3 years)	Strengthened collective voice of micro-entrepreneurs in policy processes; improved community-level resource pooling during disruptions
Academic Researchers	Conduct primary qualitative research — life history interviews, ethnographic observation, participatory action	Secondary data corpus reveals geographic concentration in Boracay and Palawan; findings from	Ongoing	More representative and transferable evidence base for policy and practice; validated or refined

	research — with tourism micro-entrepreneurs in underrepresented destinations (Samar-Leyte, Camiguin, Batanes, Zamboanga Peninsula)	underrepresented destinations needed to test typology generalizability and identify destination-specific survival strategy variants		survival strategy typology
Academic Researchers	Develop gender-disaggregated research agenda on tourism micro-enterprise survival in the Philippines; examine intersectional vulnerabilities of women, elderly, and indigenous operators in enclave contexts	ILO (2020) documents systematic gender gaps in survival outcomes; Philippine secondary data corpus virtually silent on gender dimension — a major research and policy blind spot	Ongoing	Evidence base for gender-responsive tourism micro-enterprise policy; elimination of gender blind spot in Philippine tourism MSME scholarship

Priority Recommendation: The Informal Operator Inclusion Imperative

While all recommendations in Table 7 are analytically grounded and practically actionable, the single most consequential recommendation across all stakeholder groups is the elimination of formalization requirements as preconditions for crisis relief and support program access. This recommendation is supported by the most consistent finding in the secondary data corpus — the systematic exclusion of the majority of tourism enclave micro-entrepreneurs from government support programs due to their informal operating status — and addresses the primary mechanism through which policy misalignment translates into preventable enterprise exit and livelihood destruction during disruptions.

Implementing this recommendation does not require the elimination of formalization as a policy goal; rather, it requires the decoupling of formalization from crisis relief eligibility.

Operators who cannot navigate formal registration processes under normal conditions certainly cannot do so under crisis conditions. Practical mechanisms for achieving this decoupling include: the acceptance of barangay certification or community leader attestation as documentation for crisis relief access; the creation of simplified emergency business registration pathways with waived fees during declared disaster periods; and the use of LGU micro-enterprise registers — which can capture informal operators not covered by DTI registration databases — as the primary targeting instrument for crisis support delivery.

Recommendation for Future Research

Beyond the policy recommendations addressed to government agencies and LGUs, this study generates a research agenda that the academic community should prioritize in order to provide the primary empirical evidence base that secondary data analysis alone cannot supply. Five specific research directions emerge as most urgently needed.

1. Primary qualitative research — including life history interviews, participatory action research, and longitudinal ethnographic studies — with tourism micro-entrepreneurs in underrepresented Philippine destinations: Samar-Leyte, Camiguin, Batanes, Zamboanga Peninsula, and the Caraga region. The geographic concentration of the existing literature in Boracay and Palawan limits the generalizability of current findings and leaves the survival dynamics of micro-entrepreneurs in less prominent destinations effectively invisible to researchers and policy makers.
2. Gender-disaggregated primary research on tourism micro-enterprise survival in the Philippines, with specific attention to the intersectional vulnerabilities of women-operated micro-enterprises in island and coastal enclave contexts. The near-complete absence of

gender analysis in the Philippines-specific secondary corpus represents both a scholarly lacuna and a policy blind spot with real consequences for the women who constitute the majority of food and retail micro-enterprise operators in Philippine tourism enclaves.

3. Longitudinal panel studies tracking tourism micro-enterprise survival, exit, and recovery across multiple disruption cycles in the same destinations. The cross-sectional character of most existing studies prevents the analysis of the compound disruption dynamics and resilience depletion processes that the secondary data synthesis identifies as central to understanding long-term micro-enterprise vulnerability. Longitudinal designs are essential for capturing these temporal dynamics.
4. Comparative studies examining the differential effectiveness of LGU-level and national-level micro-enterprise support programs during disruptions, with specific attention to the institutional, fiscal, and governance conditions that enable LGU-level innovation. The Siargao and Bohol cases suggest that local institutional capacity is the critical variable in micro-enterprise support effectiveness, but the conditions that produce this capacity — and the policy levers that could replicate it across more LGUs — are not yet well understood.
5. Action research in partnership with tourism micro-enterprise communities to design, pilot, and evaluate community-based resilience building programs that strengthen social capital networks, build financial literacy and savings discipline, and improve digital market access — the three intervention areas most consistently identified in the secondary data as key enablers of Quadrant II and IV survival strategies among vulnerable operators.

Theoretical Implications and Contributions to Knowledge

Beyond its policy contributions, this study makes a number of theoretical contributions to the scholarly literatures that frame it — contributions that have implications for how tourism micro-enterprise resilience is conceptualized, studied, and addressed in academic and policy discourse more broadly.

The concept of compounded resilience depletion — introduced in Chapter IV and grounded in the compound disruption dynamics documented in the secondary data — advances Resilience Theory's treatment of adaptive capacity as a dynamic stock rather than a stable property. This conceptual refinement has practical implications: if resilience is depleted through successive disruptions, then resilience-building is not a one-time investment but an ongoing maintenance imperative, and policies designed to build resilience only in response to individual disruption events will systematically underinvest in the between-disruption replenishment of adaptive capacity stocks.

The application of the Sustainable Livelihoods Framework to Philippine tourism enclave micro-entrepreneurs highlights the distinctive role of culturally specific social capital forms — *utang na loob*, *bayanihan*, *paluwagan* — as livelihood assets that operate through mechanisms distinct from the generic social capital constructs of Western academic literature. This finding invites a broader methodological reflection: the direct application of theoretical frameworks developed in Western or international contexts to Philippine and Southeast Asian realities requires careful attention to the cultural specificity of the mechanisms through which capital assets are accumulated, mobilized, and deployed. Culturally grounded adaptation of frameworks is not a concession to particularism but a methodological necessity for generating contextually valid and practically actionable knowledge.

The study's demonstration that qualitative secondary data analysis can generate substantive, policy-relevant insights about micro-entrepreneurial survival — without primary data collection — contributes to the methodological literature on QSDA and documentary analysis in tourism and entrepreneurship research. In contexts where resource constraints, geographic dispersion, and the informality of research subjects make primary data collection challenging, rigorous QSDA offers a legitimate and valuable methodological pathway that the research community should more fully recognize and deploy.

Limitations and Directions for Future Research

This study's conclusions and recommendations are offered with full acknowledgment of the limitations that bound their scope and transferability, as detailed in Chapter I. The reliance on secondary data means that the findings reflect the phenomena as documented by prior researchers and institutional authors, not as experienced directly by micro-entrepreneurs themselves. The geographic unevenness of the secondary data corpus — concentrated in Boracay, Palawan, and Bohol — may introduce destination-specific biases into the typology and mediating variable analysis. The absence of primary data on gender dynamics limits the depth of gender analysis that the study can offer, despite the clear policy importance of this dimension.

These limitations are not grounds for dismissing the study's contributions but for situating them appropriately and for committing to the primary research agenda that can address them. The survival strategy typology developed here is presented not as a finished theoretical product but as a working analytical framework whose generalizability, completeness, and predictive validity must be tested through primary empirical research across a broader range of Philippine tourism enclave contexts. Each of the five research directions identified in the recommendations section

above represents a specific pathway for building the primary evidence base that can validate, refine, or challenge the framework this study has constructed.

The broader aspiration of this work — and the aspiration that should animate the research agenda it generates — is the development of a genuinely Philippine, genuinely community-grounded understanding of tourism micro-enterprise resilience: one that begins from the lived realities of the tricycle drivers, sari-sari store operators, boat owners, and food stall vendors whose livelihoods constitute the human foundation of Philippine tourism, and that generates knowledge capable of strengthening those livelihoods against the disruptions that are, as this study has documented, a structurally recurring feature of the environment in which they operate.

Closing Statement

This study began with the observation that beneath the macro-level statistics of Philippine tourism — the arrival figures, the GDP contributions, the foreign exchange receipts — lies a more complex and more human economic reality: millions of micro-entrepreneurs in coastal and island communities whose livelihoods are tethered to the rhythms of tourist demand and whose resilience is tested repeatedly by disruptions they did not cause and cannot individually prevent. The analysis conducted across five chapters has rendered that reality more visible, more analytically tractable, and more amenable to informed policy action than it was before.

The micro-entrepreneurs documented in this study are not footnotes to the Philippine tourism economy; they are its ground floor. The sari-sari store operator in Boracay who pivoted to community delivery during the closure, the boat operator in Siargao who organized a paluwagan to survive the pandemic, the food stall vendor in Bohol who activated her utang na loob network to resume operations after the earthquake — these actors demonstrate the very adaptive

resourcefulness that resilience frameworks celebrate, often without any of the institutional support that those frameworks assume. They deserve a policy architecture commensurate with their contribution and responsive to their vulnerability. This study is offered as a contribution, however partial, toward making that architecture a reality.

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